The Monroe Doctrine

President James Monroe · Seventh Annual Message to Congress · December 2, 1823

Source: James Monroe, Seventh Annual Message to Congress (Dec. 2, 1823), text via The American Presidency Project, UC Santa Barbara. Public domain.

Latin American independence movements in the 1810s–20s left several new republics (Mexico, Colombia, Argentina, Chile) vulnerable to European reconquest. With the encouragement of Secretary of State John Quincy Adams, Monroe announced — inside a routine annual message to Congress — that the Western Hemisphere was closed to further European colonization and that the U.S. would view interference as an act of hostility. Tacitly underwritten by the British Royal Navy, the doctrine became a long-term foundation of U.S. foreign policy.

Connect: The Era of Good Feelings ended fast. What tensions from Class 8 (Missouri Compromise, sectionalism) helped destroy it?

Key Passages

Non-colonization

the American continents, by the free and independent condition which they have assumed and maintain, are henceforth not to be considered as subjects for future colonization by any European powers.

Two political systems

we should consider any attempt on their part to extend their system to any portion of this hemisphere as dangerous to our peace and safety. … we could not view any interposition for the purpose of oppressing them, or controlling in any other manner their destiny, by any European power in any other light than as the manifestation of an unfriendly disposition toward the United States.

Non-intervention pledge

Our policy in regard to Europe, which was adopted at an early stage of the wars which have so long agitated that quarter of the globe, nevertheless remains the same, which is, not to interfere in the internal concerns of any of its powers

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	Independence movements in Latin America (1810s-20s) left new republics vulnerable to European reconquest, and Russia was pressing claims in the Pacific Northwest.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Congress and the American public, and indirectly the European powers, especially the Holy Alliance, Russia, and Britain.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	President James Monroe, with Secretary of State John Quincy Adams, representing a young, militarily weak United States that wanted influence in its own hemisphere.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. Contextualization (DBQ/LEQ, 1 pt): In one paragraph, place the Monroe Doctrine in the broader post-Napoleonic, post-Latin-American-independence context of the 1820s.
2. Why did the U.S. have the audacity — but not really the power — to issue this declaration in 1823?
3. Trace ONE later application of the Monroe Doctrine (e.g., Polk, Roosevelt Corollary, Cold War interventions).